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UNHCR PREPARATORIA

Background

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Introduction to the committee:

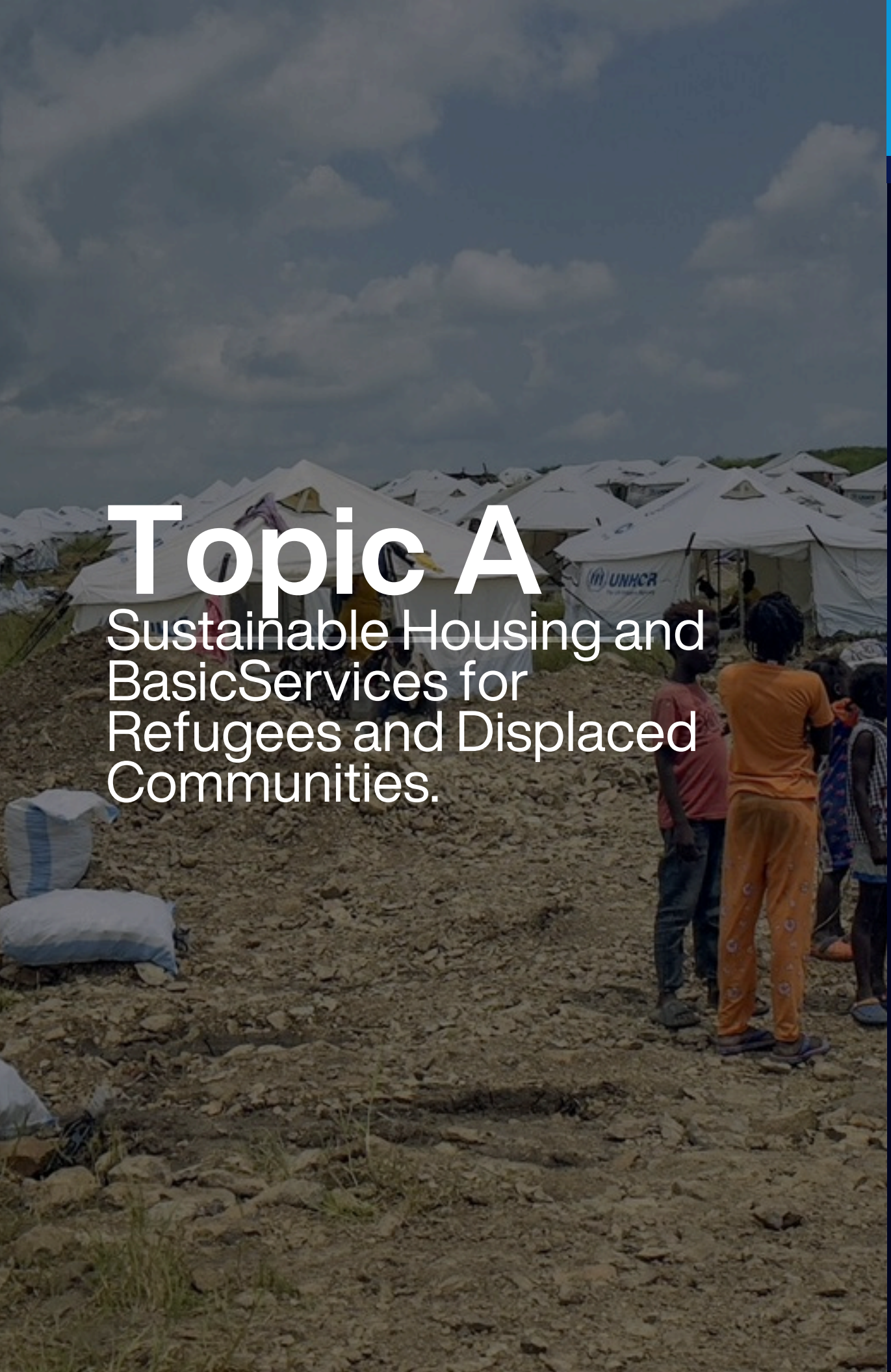
The United Nations High Commissioner for Refugees (UNHCR) is a United Nations agency established in 1950 to protect and assist refugees and other people forced to flee their homes. Its work includes providing international protection, assistance, shelter, access to basic services, and support for long-term solutions. UNHCR works with Member States, international organizations, civil society, and affected communities to respond to displacement and promote the rights and well-being of displaced populations. Its mandate is closely connected to the 1951 Convention relating to the Status of Refugees and its 1967 Protocol.

Forced displacement is influenced by several factors, including conflict, persecution, violence, disasters, poverty, and environmental pressures. These circumstances can create significant challenges for displaced people, particularly regarding access to adequate housing, clean water, sanitation, healthcare, education, and other essential services. UNHCR therefore considers both immediate humanitarian assistance and longer-term solutions important for protecting displaced populations.

The work of UNHCR is also connected to Sustainability and Indigenous Peoples. Sustainable development can improve living conditions for displaced populations while reducing pressure on natural resources and host communities. In addition, Indigenous Peoples can contribute traditional knowledge and sustainable practices to environmental protection and climate adaptation. The committee must therefore consider how international cooperation can protect displaced populations while promoting sustainable, inclusive, and environmentally responsible solutions.







Topic A

Sustainable Housing and BasicServices for Refugees and Displaced Communities.

Guiding Question

How can the international community ensure access to safe, sustainable housing and basic services for refugees and displaced communities while protecting the environment and supporting host communities?

Access to adequate housing and basic services is an essential part of protecting refugees and displaced communities. People forced to leave their homes may depend on temporary shelters, camps, reception centers, or host communities. In situations of prolonged displacement, inadequate housing can expose people to health risks, extreme weather, overcrowding, and limited access to essential resources. Access to clean water, sanitation, healthcare, education, energy, and food is also necessary for maintaining safe and dignified living conditions.

Sustainable housing seeks to provide safe and durable accommodation while considering environmental, economic, and social factors. Sustainable solutions can include energy-efficient buildings, responsible use of construction materials, water conservation, waste management, renewable energy, and infrastructure adapted to local environmental conditions. These measures can also benefit host communities by reducing pressure on local resources.

UNHCR works with governments, humanitarian organizations, development agencies, and local communities to improve shelter and essential services for displaced populations. However, major challenges remain, particularly in countries with limited financial resources or infrastructure. Another important consideration is ensuring that displaced people and local communities participate in decisions affecting their living conditions.

The topic therefore requires balancing immediate humanitarian needs with long-term sustainability and resilience. International cooperation can help governments and humanitarian organizations provide adequate services while promoting environmentally responsible development.





> "Housing is not simply about a roof over one's head. It is a fundamental human right and the foundation upon which peace itself rests."
> -Amina J. Mohammed, UN Deputy Secretary-General

Historical context

The international protection of refugees developed significantly following the Second World War. In 1951, the Convention relating to the Status of Refugees established an international legal framework for protecting refugees and defining their rights. The 1967 Protocol later expanded the Convention's application by removing its original temporal and geographical limitations.

As forced displacement continued to increase, international responses expanded beyond immediate protection to include shelter, water, sanitation, healthcare, education, and livelihood opportunities. Humanitarian organizations increasingly recognized that displaced populations may remain displaced for extended periods and therefore require more sustainable living conditions.

The Sustainable Development Goals (SDGs. They are a set of 17 global goals adopted by all United Nations (UN) member states in 2015 as part of the 2030 Agenda, adopted by the United Nations in 2015, to address humanitarian and sustainable development. SDG 6 focuses on clean water and sanitation, SDG 7 on affordable and clean energy, SDG 11 on sustainable cities and communities, and SDG 13 on climate action. These objectives are relevant to refugee-hosting communities because sustainable infrastructure can benefit both displaced populations and host populations.

The Global Compact on Refugees, affirmed by the UN General Assembly in 2018, strengthened the international focus on responsibility-sharing and support for refugees and host communities. It recognizes that refugee situations require cooperation between humanitarian, development, and other international actors.

These developments demonstrate a gradual transition from short-term emergency assistance toward approaches that combine protection, development, sustainability, and long-term solutions.

Example of historical context

After World War II, the 1951 Refugee Convention and 1967 Protocol established international refugee protection. Over time, humanitarian efforts expanded to include basic services and sustainable housing, reinforced by the 2015 Sustainable Development Goals and the 2018 Global Compact on Refugees, which promoted international cooperation and shared responsibility.





Measures taken

UNHCR has developed several approaches to improve living conditions for refugees and displaced populations. Its shelter and settlement work seeks to provide safe and dignified accommodation while considering the needs of both displaced people and host communities. UNHCR also works to improve access to water, sanitation, hygiene, energy, and other essential services.

The Global Compact on Refugees promotes greater international responsibility-sharing and encourages cooperation between governments, humanitarian organizations, development actors, financial institutions, civil society, and the private sector. This approach recognizes that countries hosting large displaced populations may require additional financial and technical support.

The 2030 Agenda for Sustainable Development also provides a framework for addressing challenges affecting displaced communities. Sustainable housing, clean water, sanitation, energy, and resilient communities contribute to the achievement of several Sustainable Development Goals.



UNHCR has increasingly incorporated environmental sustainability into its operations. Measures can include reducing environmental impacts, improving resource efficiency, supporting sustainable energy, and considering environmental risks when planning settlements and infrastructure.

However, important limitations remain. Many refugee-hosting countries face financial constraints, rapid population growth, limited infrastructure, and environmental pressures.

Humanitarian funding can also prioritize immediate emergencies rather than long-term development. International cooperation, financing, technical assistance, sustainable infrastructure, and partnerships with host and displaced communities.

> “Everyone has the right to a standard of living adequate for the health and well-being of himself and of his family, including food, clothing, housing and medical care and necessary social services.”
> -United Nations, Universal Declaration of Human Rights, Article 25

Guiding Questions

1. What is the official position of the delegate's country regarding sustainable housing for refugees and displaced communities?
2. What policies has the country implemented to provide housing and basic services to displaced populations?
3. What are the main challenges faced by displaced populations in accessing water, sanitation, healthcare, education, and energy?
4. How does the country support refugee-hosting communities?
5. What international organizations does the country cooperate with to improve housing and basic services?
6. What financial or technical resources does the country provide or receive for sustainable infrastructure?
7. How can sustainable housing reduce environmental pressure on host communities?
8. How can Indigenous and local communities participate in decisions regarding housing and infrastructure?
9. Which countries could become potential allies in promoting sustainable housing and basic services?
10. What measures could the country propose to improve existing international programs without duplicating them?



Topic B

Climate Change Adaptation andthe Protection of Displaced Populations

Guiding Question

How can the international community protect climate-displaced populations while strengthening climate adaptation and resilience?

Climate change is increasingly affecting populations vulnerable to displacement. Floods, droughts, storms, wildfires, rising sea levels, and extreme temperatures can damage homes, infrastructure, ecosystems, and livelihoods. These impacts can force people to move temporarily or permanently and can increase existing vulnerabilities. Climate change can also interact with poverty, conflict, food insecurity, and limited access to resources, making displacement more difficult to prevent and manage.

Climate change adaptation refers to actions that reduce vulnerability and increase the ability of communities to respond to climate-related risks. For displaced populations, adaptation can include resilient infrastructure, early-warning systems, disaster preparedness, water security, sustainable livelihoods, and environmental protection.

UNHCR, IOM, UNDP, UNDRR, UNFCCC, governments, NGOs, and local communities all have roles in addressing climate-related displacement. However, an important legal issue is that people displaced solely because of climate-related events do not automatically qualify asrefugees under the 1951 Refugee Convention. This creates a need to examine complementary forms of humanitarian protection while maintaining existing international refugee law.

The topic therefore focuses on how States can prevent displacement where possible, protect people who are forced to move, and develop sustainable long-term solutions. Indigenous Peoples and local communities should also be considered because their traditional knowledge and connection to their territories can contribute to climate adaptation and environmental resilience.





> "Early warning systems save lives. Climate-smart agriculture and infrastructure save jobs."
> -António Guterres, Secretary General of the UN

Historical context

The international refugee protection system was established through the 1951 Convention and expanded by the 1967 Protocol. However, climate-related displacement alone does not automatically grant refugee status under these agreements.

In 2010, the Cancun Adaptation Framework recognized migration, displacement, and planned relocation as consequences of climate change. In 2012, the Nansen Initiative was created to address the protection needs of people displaced by disasters and climate-related events.

In 2015, the Paris Agreement strengthened international cooperation on climate adaptation, while the Sendai Framework promoted disaster preparedness and resilience. That same year, 109 States endorsed the Nansen Initiative's Protection Agenda to improve protection for disaster-displaced populations.

In 2016, the Platform on Disaster Displacement was established to continue these efforts. UNHCR has also strengthened its climate action through its Strategic Plan for Climate Action 2024–2030, supporting displaced populations and host communities.

Despite these developments, challenges remain because there is no single international legal framework that automatically grants refugee status to people displaced by climate change. Limited funding, inadequate infrastructure, and gaps in legal protection make stronger international cooperation essential.

Example of historical context

The growing impact of climate change on human displacement led to the recognition of migration and planned relocation in the 2010 Cancun Adaptation Framework. In 2015, the Nansen Initiative Protection Agenda and the Paris Agreement strengthened international cooperation to protect disaster-displaced populations and improve climate resilience, paving the way for the Platform on Disaster Displacement in 2016.





Measures taken

The international community has taken important measures to address climate-related displacement. The 2010 Cancun Adaptation Framework recognized displacement as a consequence of climate change, while the 2015 Paris Agreement promoted adaptation and resilience. The Sendai Framework for Disaster Risk Reduction also encourages countries to strengthen early-warning systems and disaster preparedness.

In 2015, the Nansen Initiative Protection Agenda, endorsed by 109 States, promoted the protection of people displaced by disasters. In 2016, the Platform on Disaster Displacement (PDD) continued these efforts through international cooperation and policy development.

Additionally, UNHCR's Strategic Plan for Climate Action 2024–2030 supports displaced populations and host communities by strengthening resilience and improving access to essential services. However, challenges remain in funding, legal protection, and helping vulnerable communities adapt to climate change.

The International Organization for Migration (IOM) also works to address climate-related displacement by supporting governments in developing migration policies, disaster preparedness plans, and relocation strategies. Its initiatives promote safer movement and help communities adapt to environmental changes. These efforts complement UNHCR's work by connecting climate adaptation, migration management, and humanitarian assistance.





"At the heart of this issue lies the fate of millions of people who contributed almost nothing to global carbon emissions, but are among those paying the highest price."
-Filippo Grandi, former UN High Commissioner for Refugees

Guiding Questions

1. What is the official position of the delegate's country regarding climate-related displacement?
2. What climate-related risks currently threaten the country's population?
3. What national policies has the country implemented to adapt to climate change?
4. What measures has the country taken to prevent climate-related d isplacement ?
5. Does the country support temporary humanitarian protection for people displaced by severe climate-related disasters?
6. What role does the country play in UNHCR, IOM, UNFCCC, UNDRR, or other relevant international organizations?
7. What financial or technical assistance does the country provide or receive for climate adaptation?
8. How can Indigenous Peoples and local communities contribute to climate adaptation strategies?
9. Which countries could become potential allies in developing sustainable solutions to climate-related displacement?
10. What measures could the country propose to strengthen protection for climate-displaced populations while maintaining the existing international refugee framework?

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